Exchange of fire
The vans of the French (left) and British (right) fleets engage at Chesapeake Bay. The center and rear squadrons remain unengaged due to the angle at which the two lines approached.

1 THE BRITISH FLEET ARRIVES
After finding the Chesapeake unoccupied by the French, the British under Rear Admiral Hood set sail for New York to report to Admiral Graves. When they return, they find the French blockading the bay. De Grasse immediately attacks.

CHESAPEAKE BAY

French fleet blockading Chesapeake Bay

British form line ahead and bear down on French from the north

British miss opportunity of attacking isolated French van. Hood currently in British van

Wind

"Promiscuous" line of French ships sets sail to engage British fleet. Van pulls ahead of center and rear squadrons

ATLANTIC OCEAN

KEY

FRENCH FLEET

2 French ships of the line

BRITISH FLEET

2–3 British ships of the line

"SIR SAMUEL WOULD BE GLAD TO SEND AN OPINION, BUT KNOWS NOT WHAT TO SAY IN THE TRULY LAMENTABLE STATE WE HAVE BROUGHT OURSELVES."

REAR ADMIRAL SIR SAMUEL HOOD, IN A COMMUNICATION TO ADMIRAL GRAVES